EXPERIMENT 7

Experiment with different layouts and color schemes for an app. Collect user feedback on aesthetics and usability.

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Testing app aesthetics doesn't require expensive enterprise software. **GIMP (GNU Image Manipulation Program)** is a powerhouse for creating high-fidelity mockups and experimenting with visual hierarchy without spending a dime.

Below is a refined, professional workflow for iterating on app designs and validating them with real users.

Objective

To systematically design, vary, and evaluate mobile app interfaces using GIMP, focusing on how color theory and layout impact user experience (UX) and visual appeal.

Phase 1: Setting Up the Workspace

1. Environment Preparation

- **Install GIMP:** Grab the latest stable build from gimp.org.
- **Canvas Setup:** Go to **File > New**. For a standard modern smartphone screen, use **1080 x 1920 pixels**.
- **Pro-Tip:** Set your **X and Y resolution to 72 pixels/in**, as this is the standard for digital screen displays.

2. Structuring the Architecture (Layers are Life)

In GIMP, your layers are your best friends. Never draw on the "Background" layer.

- **Create Folders:** Use the Layer Dialogue to create folders for **Header**, **Body**, and **Footer**.

- **Blocking:** Use the **Rectangle Select Tool (R)** to map out your regions. Use the **Bucket Fill Tool (Shift + B)** to drop in neutral grays initially to focus on layout before color.

Phase 2: UI Component Design

1. Adding Interactive Elements

- **Typography:** Use the **Text Tool (T)**. Use a clean, sans-serif font (like Roboto or Open Sans) for readability.
- **Buttons & Inputs:** Create a new layer, select a rounded rectangle, and fill it.
- **Icons:** Import transparent PNG icons or use the **Path Tool (B)** to custom-draw simple shapes.

2. Functional Organization

Label your layers clearly (e.g., Btn_Submit_Active, Nav_Home_Icon). This makes "Phase 3" significantly faster.

Phase 3: The Color Experiment (A/B Variants)

The goal is to see how different palettes change the "mood" of the app.

1. **The Master Copy:** Once your layout is perfect, go to **Image > Duplicate**. Do this three times to create three distinct versions.
2. **Applying Schemes:**
    - **Variant A (Corporate/Clean):** High contrast, blues, and whites.
    - **Variant B (Dark Mode):** Deep grays, blacks, and neon accent colors.
    - **Variant C (Playful/Vibrant):** Warm tones, oranges, or gradients.
3. **The Colorize Tool:** Use **Colors > Colorize** or **Hue-Saturation** to quickly flip the vibe of a layer without redrawing it.

Phase 4: Feedback & Validation

1. Exporting for Review

Export each variant as a high-quality PNG: **File > Export As > Layout_v1_Blue.png**.

2. The Feedback Loop

Create a structured survey (Google Forms or Typeform) and present your variants side-by-side. Ask specific, measurable questions:

- *"On a scale of 1-10, how easy is it to find the 'Search' bar?"*
- *"Which color scheme feels most 'trustworthy'?"*
- *"Is the text legible against the background color?"*

Phase 5: Refinement & "The Cutover"

Analyze the data. If 80% of users preferred "Variant B" but found the button text hard to read, go back to GIMP and:

- Adjust the contrast ratio.
- Increase font weight.
- Finalize the assets for developer hand-off.

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